

# The art of stone skimming

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**H**ow often have we done this on picnics or on the way to school if there was a body of water available? Picked up a flat stone, and thrown, hoping the skimming stone would touch the water three, four, five, times before disappearing?

It is as natural as kicking a stone (that's probably how football began), or punching someone (boxing?).

In this column's continuing efforts to educate and entertain, let me present another sport which has just concluded its world championship: Stone skimming.

The coaching manual is clear on how to throw: Draw your arm and wrist back. Drive forward using your body and hips, not just your arm. Whip your wrist at the very last second, letting the index finger rip across the stone's edge to generate a fast, stabilising spin (the gyroscopic effect). Release the thumb at the final moment. Aim for the stone to strike the water at a shallow angle — roughly 10 to 20 degrees.

**How delightfully complicated! Had we read that in school, none of us would have been able to send a stone skimming on the water.**

Recently, some 400 of the best arrived on the tiny island of Easdale off the coast of Scotland, briefly increasing its population by 700 per cent. This is where the World Stone Skimming Championship was held. Easdale is to stone skimming what Lord's (or Ahmedabad) is to cricket. It is a former slate mine



**Going global:** Recently, some 400 of the best in stone skimming arrived on the tiny island of Easdale off the coast of Scotland, briefly increasing its population by 700 per cent. This is where the World Stone Skimming Championship was held. PIC FOR REPRESENTATION PURPOSE / GETTY IMAGES

flooded by a storm in 1881 which left a natural amphitheatre for the tournament. Each competitor gets three throws across the 63-metre stretch; stones cannot be wider than 7.6 cm and must hit the back wall.

Sounds simple? Ah! But there's the wind and the rain and the shadows on the water (marked like swimming lanes) to negotiate. On placid water and with nothing at stake, most skimmers (not tossers, as they might be easily referred to — although the organiser is called the Official Toss Master) can throw twice that distance, but here not many make it. By the halfway stage, this year, only one competitor had hit the wall.

**This year was special in that there were two geologists to check the stones.** Stone skimming had a world class scandal last year when two competitors were caught cheating, having shaped their stones into perfect circles for better throws.

The Toss Master was quoted as saying, "We are often put in the same category as cheese chasing down the hill, but these skimmers have genuine sporting talent. The world record for the javelin is nearly 100 metres. The record for stone skimming is much farther than that." If Neeraj Chopra is looking for a change of career when he retires...

As the only one to hit the wall, Liam Knight from North Carolina became the new champion. "I had to use a technique that nobody else was using to get it out past the wind," he explained later.

It is a lesson for all sport, perhaps life itself. Even skimming requires deep understanding.